

9 Conclusion

Part 2: Objections, Cultural Context, and Personal Reflections

9.3 Select objections to intuitionism

A variety of objections have been raised to ethical intuitionism. Following are the four most common.

9.3.1 'Intuition cannot be proven to be reliable'

Some say that we cannot know moral truths by means of intuition unless we can first verify that intuition in general is reliable. Those who make this objection would not be satisfied by the use of intuitions to support other intuitions—showing, in other words, that one has an internally coherent system of intuitions. Nor would they be satisfied by a showing that one's intuitions cohere with those of other people. Rather, the objectors seek a verification of the reliability of intuition that does not itself rely on anyone's intuition at any point.

No such verification can be produced. But this is not a problem, for at least two reasons. First, because no such verification exists for sense perception, memory, introspection, or reason in general, either. No one can prove that sense perception is generally reliable, using only non-perceptual evidence. No one can prove that memory is generally reliable, using only information gathered at the present instant in time. No one can prove reason to be reliable, without using reason. But we do not declare all of these forms of cognition illegitimate. To do so would land us in the pit of universal skepticism. It appears, then, that the present objection relies on an epistemological double-standard: the objector imposes demands on intuition that would not be placed on any other fundamental source of knowledge.

Second, the demand was never justified in the first place. Why should any process of cognition demand a second cognitive process directed at the first one? Why not instead hold, in accordance with the principle of Phenomenal Conservatism, that our cognitive faculties are presumed innocent until proven guilty? This avoids dogmatism by leaving us open to the possibility of revising our initial beliefs if new evidence should appear defeating them, but it also avoids the extreme skepticism that would never allow us any starting points at all for our belief systems.

The demand for verification of reliability would seem appropriate if we conceived intuition (and perception, memory, and so on) as giving us immediate awareness of mental states, from which we try to infer conclusions about the real world. Such an inference would require the prior assumption of a correlation between such mental states and states of the real world, an assumption which would require justification. But as I have urged above, this would be a misunderstanding of the role of intuition; we should conceive of intuitions, like perceptual experiences and memory experiences, as merely vehicles of the awareness of facts that exist independent of them.

9.3.2 'Intuitionists cannot explain disagreement'

Some claim that intuitionism makes it impossible to understand how moral error and moral disagreement can occur. Those who press this objection often seem to have in mind an infallibilistic caricature of intuitionism that probably does not correspond to any actual intuitionist's views. Indeed, it is hard enough to find philosophers who claim infallibility about anything, let alone ethics.

Those who avoid unfairly caricaturing intuitionism argue simply that there is more error and disagreement than one would expect if intuitionism were true. There are at least four reasons why they are mistaken. First, they typically exaggerate the amount of disagreement and error that exists. While there is widespread disagreement about such issues as abortion, affirmative action, and capital punishment, there are no serious disputes about the desirability of such things as murder, rape, and armed robbery. The former sort of issues receive much more attention than the latter, simply because we don't normally discuss what everyone already knows. This leads to an exaggerated view of the prevalence of controversy.

Second, human error and disagreement are common with respect to many objective, factual questions. People sharply disagree about such things as who shot JFK, whether a particular basketball player is better than another, whether a particular individual is smarter than another, whether there is a God, and virtually every major issue in philosophy. Furthermore, throughout history, almost everyone who has held any views at all about them has held radically erroneous views about such things as: the causes of health and disease, the structure of the cosmos, the origin of the human

species, the existence of disembodied spirits, the composition of the physical world, and the workings of the economy, to name a few. But no one concludes either that these matters are all 'subjective' or that human beings lack any legitimate cognitive faculties capable of knowing about them.

Third, in general, even when we have available a valid means of cognition, human beings are subject to a great variety of causes of error. These include bias, oversight, miscalculation, confusion, false or incomplete information, and logical fallacies, among others. It is a naive philosopher indeed who thinks that intellectual processes nearly always run smoothly and cleanly, with no defects or non-rational influences. There is no obvious reason why the problems that lead to errors and disagreements about so many other things would not occur when people think about values. Here, as with the previous objection, an epistemological double-standard is being applied: almost no one takes the validity of other means of cognition, such as empirical reasoning, to be refuted by the existence of widespread errors and disagreements, nor by our susceptibility to mistakes and non-rational influences of various kinds. Only intuition is taken to be impugned by such facts. Of course, the facts do warrant our being cautious in our ethical claims, just as we should be cautious in our claims about the other matters of controversy mentioned above.

Fourth, if we consider what sorts of issues people generally disagree about the most and make the most errors about, it is easily predictable that moral matters would be among them. For people tend to disagree and make errors the most about (a) issues they are strongly biased about, including but not limited to those in which their own interests are at stake, (b) issues on which their beliefs are largely based on cultural indoctrination, (c) issues on which their beliefs are largely based on religion, and (d) philosophical issues in general. This is true regardless of whether the issues in question are evaluative. Since moral issues fall into all four of these categories, it is to be expected that disagreement and error would be common with respect to moral issues. Thus, there is nothing surprising in the phenomenon of moral disagreement that calls for an anti-realist interpretation.

9.3.3 'Intuitionists cannot resolve disagreements'

Some object that intuitionism gives us no reasonable method for resolving moral disagreements. The most initially plausible form of the objection claims that there are many differences of intuitions, and that intuitionists have no method for adjudicating between contrary intuitions.

This objection fails for several reasons. First, some ethical intuitions may cohere better or worse with the rest of our intuitions. Thus, moral philosophers commonly argue for positions on controversial moral issues by appealing to our intuitions about (allegedly) analogous cases. They also often appeal to intuitions about what sorts of factors may be morally relevant. These are just two of the ways in which other intuitions may be brought to bear on controversial ones.

Second, we can use our knowledge of the factors that tend to affect the reliability of people's beliefs to determine which intuitions are most likely to be correct. We may have reason to believe that certain moral intuitions are unduly influenced by bias, indoctrination, religion, and so on. This is true, for example, of many moral attitudes pertaining to sexuality and reproduction.

Third, even if some moral disputes turn out to be unresolvable, it is obscure how this is supposed to refute intuitionism. There are many disputes, about both moral and non-moral matters, that appear for all practical purposes unresolvable. Why should we assume that, on the correct theory, all moral disputes would be resolvable? Once again, the objection to intuitionism rests on a double standard: for no other fundamental knowledge source do we demand an algorithm for resolving all disputes.

Fourth, the objection rests on another double standard: no other metaethical theory is typically subjected to the demand to provide a method of resolving all moral disputes—and no other metaethical theory can do so. Neither the non-cognitivists, nor the subjectivists, nor the naturalists have produced a method of securing agreement on the morality of abortion, capital punishment, and the like.

Finally, all versions of the 'disagreement' objection appear to be self-refuting. Those who give the objection claim that their objection itself, together with the metaethical conclusion that it supports, is objectively correct. Yet many intelligent people continue to disagree with the argument from disagreement, and with each metaethical theory. How can anti-realists or naturalists explain this disagreement? And how can they resolve it? The prospects for resolving this disagreement seem no better than the prospects for resolving the disagreement about the morality of abortion.

9.3.4 'Intuitionism is weird'

Many consider ethical intuitionism too 'weird' or 'mysterious' to be embraced. There are two parts to this criticism: (a) irreducible moral facts are a weird kind of fact; (b) intuition is a weird way of knowing.

It is unclear what this criticism amounts to. Is there an objective property of 'weirdness'? If there are no objective values, then it is doubtful that there is objective weirdness either. But if there is not, then it is hard to see how the alleged weirdness of intuitionism would count as evidence against it. If, for example, 'x is weird' just expresses a subjective reaction towards x, then it provides no argument against the reality of x.

If there is objective weirdness, what does it consist in? Consider three interpretations. First, perhaps 'weird' means 'very different from most other things'. Moral facts are very different from other kinds of facts, and intuition is very different from other kinds of awareness. But how would this tend to show that either moral facts or moral intuition doesn't exist? We live in a diverse world: there are many things we know of that are very different from each other.

Second, perhaps 'weird' means 'counter-intuitive'. But the existence of moral facts is not counter-intuitive. Ordinary moral discourse, in which we all engage on a daily basis, is committed to the existence of moral facts. And as my arguments against subjectivism show, and as is commonly accepted even among anti-realists, we ordinarily think of these facts as objective. It would be difficult to argue that it is the intuitionist who is taking a counter-intuitive position.

Third, perhaps 'weird' means 'poorly understood'. But again, we lack any clear reason for thinking that things which are weird in that sense do not exist. Nor is there any obvious reason for thinking that either moral properties or moral intuition is less well understood than many other things whose existence we accept, such as consciousness, numbers, dispositional properties, possibilities, time, space, fields, aesthetic properties, and propositions.

The argument from weirdness, then, is as obscure as it is influential. It is highly obscure what weirdness is, or how the charge of weirdness provides an objection to a theory. Intuitionism may well be a 'weird' position in some sense, but if it is, this does not appear to provide any evidence against its truth.

9.4 The revolt against values: how intuitionism lost favor

That concludes my official, philosophical case for ethical intuitionism. I am now going to indulge in psychological and sociological speculation about the resistance to ethical intuitionism. This speculation will not provide evidence for intuitionism; however, it may have some logical relevance, since it will suggest that most of those who have rejected intuitionism have formed their beliefs in an unreliable way.

9.4.1 Was intuitionism rationally refuted?

Ethical intuitionism was popular among English-speaking philosophers in the early twentieth century. By mid-century, it had suffered a dramatic loss of favor, continuing to the present day. Why? One account, congenial to the anti-realists, goes like this: 'Intuitionism was the first view of ethics that occurred to people, at the dawn of analytic philosophy, because it is the simplest, most naive view. Intuitionism is similar to Plato's view of ethics, which, not coincidentally, arose at the dawn of Western philosophy. As people reflected more, they quickly noticed the various fatal flaws in the system and rationally rejected it in favor of more sophisticated and defensible theories'.

I suspect that is how many contemporary philosophers see that bit of intellectual history. But I think that is utter fantasy. In my view, the broad movements in the history of philosophy look much more like shifts in temperament and intellectual fashions than like rational movements away from unworkable theories towards more objectively defensible ones. I cannot support that judgment in a general way here, since it would call for a discussion of several major philosophical issues and episodes in the history of philosophy. But I can provide some support for the contention as it applies to ethical intuitionism and its fall from philosophical favor. Intuitionism was not rejected because it was found to be unworkable. It was rejected first, then the rejection was rationalized by a handful of paper-thin objections, including those discussed in the previous section. That this was what really happened is evidenced by two salient facts.

First, there is the fact that most of the prominent objections to intuitionism rest upon epistemological double-standards, making demands of intuition and intuitionism that would not be imposed on any other basic means of cognition, or on any other metaethical theory. This sort of reasoning is characteristic of rationalizations. And one of the main objections seems to rest on nothing more than a subjective sense of 'weirdness', which is difficult to distinguish from a mere bias.

Second, there is the fact that most, if not all of the objections to intuitionism are subject to rather simple and natural replies, requiring no significant modifications to the theory; yet the critics of intuitionism have devoted virtually no energy to considering such replies. In contrast, the more fashionable metaethical theories have been the subject of numerous elaborate, technical modifications and variations over a period of decades, designed to show how they can escape from the seemingly devastating objections that lie very close to the surface. In short, metaethicists over the past fifty years never gave ethical intuitionism anything like the serious consideration they devoted to other theories.

Of course, I deny that intuitionism was ever refuted, since I think the theory is true and that I have shown it to be true in the preceding pages of this book. But even if you think I am wrong about this, you should still agree that I have made a case for intuitionism that is about as reasonable, at least, as the case that has been made for some of the other theories in metaethics. But in the ethics literature over the past fifty years, intuitionism has been taken far less seriously and given far less attention than any of the other four metaethical theories. So, whether or not intuitionism is actually true, it seems clear that the opposition to it has been out of proportion to any objective assessment of the weight of the arguments. Some other explanation for intuitionism's fall from favor is required.

I believe that intuitionism was rejected because it does not fit with the spirit of the modern age. There are at least three important tendencies of modern, Western culture that are relevant here: cynicism, political correctness, and scientism.

9.4.2 Cynicism

In the twentieth century, everything once held in high esteem—human nature, science, truth, objective knowledge, art, philosophy, religion, morality—had to be debunked. Psychologists sought to show that Man, once considered 'the rational animal', was fundamentally irrational. Freudians found us filled with lust and socially destructive impulses; Marxists found human history dominated by greed and exploitation; sociobiologists found all aspects of human life dominated by 'selfish' drives to reproduce. All three groups found human beings massively self-deceived and considered such supposedly spiritual pursuits as art, religion, and philosophy to be covers for something shallower and far less noble than they appear. Many have remarked on how tiny and insignificant humanity is, how foolish we once were to think ourselves the center of the universe, and how ignorant and helpless we are. Many philosophers, who had once seen their discipline as a rational pursuit of fundamental truths about the nature of reality and our place in it, now denied that philosophy could tell us anything of such truths, if such truths even existed. One influential school of thought declared that philosophers could do no more than discuss how people use words, and that metaphysics, theology, and ethics were all 'meaningless'. Other philosophers declared that there is no such thing as truth, that we can never know it, that we are fundamentally irrational, and/or that objectivity is impossible. American intellectuals attacked what were once their country's most revered forebears—such as Christopher Columbus, Thomas Jefferson, and George Washington—as hypocrites, bigots, and exploiters; they attacked the Declaration of Independence and the Constitution similarly. And Western intellectuals attacked Christianity more than any other religion. Modern thinkers have sought to tear down their own society's heroes, its religion, its philosophy, its economic and political system—in short, its values.

I do not plan to explain all the intellectual developments mentioned in the preceding paragraph; I rely on the reader's familiarity with contemporary intellectual culture to recognize most of what I have just mentioned. Nor do I plan to discuss their intellectual merits—in some cases, the attitudes may have been justified, while in others they were not. My point here is that, whatever else may be said about them, all those cultural developments have at least one thing in common: cynicism. Western culture of the past fifty years must be among the most cynical cultures in world history. And that thoroughgoing cynicism has made the widespread acceptance of ethical intuitionism impossible in our culture, whatever the intellectual merits of the theory. A culture that insists that humans are fundamentally selfish and ignoble will never accept my account of moral motivation. A culture that declares the notions of truth, knowledge, and objectivity delusory will never accept my account of moral knowledge. And a culture that seeks to tear down all values will never accept moral realism. Subjectivism, non-cognitivism, and nihilism have been popular, in short, because they offer the modern mind the perverse pleasure of debunking morality.

9.4.3 Political correctness

Political correctness has two, closely-related aspects: First, the imperative to avoid giving offense, even to the most sensitive individuals. Thus, we call garbage men 'sanitation engineers'. We call stupid people 'mentally challenged'. ('Retarded' was originally a euphemism for 'stupid', but it has since come to seem even more derogatory than 'stupid'; hence the need for a new euphemism.) What was once the vice of drunkenness has become the 'disease' of alcoholism. It is particularly groups, rather than individuals, that one must be wary of offending.

Second, political correctness entails an extreme egalitarianism. To be politically correct, one must avoid saying that anyone is better than anyone else in any significant way. This is a corollary to the first rule: to deny equality might give offense to those who are judged worse.

Moral realists seem to violate both of these strictures. If there are real moral requirements, then presumably not everyone is satisfying them: sometimes, people do wrong. Some people might even have to be judged evil, if they perpetrate sufficiently serious wrongs. In any case, if there are virtues and vices, then some people will surely turn out to have more virtues and fewer vices than others: won't we then have to call these people 'morally better' than the others? But to say such a thing would surely offend those judged to be worse. Indeed, there are few more reliable ways of offending a person than calling him immoral.

Furthermore, if there are objective facts of any kind, then some beliefs—those that correspond to the facts—are presumably better than others. But again, to say this would surely give offense to those who hold the 'inferior' (that is, false) beliefs. In view of this and the preceding point, it might turn out that some cultures are morally worse than others—for they might have false moral beliefs and engage in immoral practices. If we judge, for example, that men and women really have equal rights, would we not be forced to conclude that Islamic culture is bad in a very significant respect—it embraces false moral beliefs and treats women wrongly? To say such a thing would surely offend Muslims. But how could we avoid saying such things, if we believed in objective values? It seems that, to be politically correct, we must be anti-realists.

My purpose here is not to discuss Muslim culture, the nature of evil, alcoholism, and so on. My purpose is to explain the ascendance of moral anti-realism in modern times: the popularity of anti-realism, I believe, is in large part due to the perception that moral realism would force us into uncomfortable positions that would cause offense to certain groups.

9.4.4 Scientism

To explain what scientism is, I can hardly do better than to quote Peter van Inwagen:

Scientism, as I use the word, is a sort of exaggerated respect for science—that is, for the physical and biological sciences—and a corresponding disparagement of all other areas of human intellectual endeavour. It hardly need be pointed out that scientism is the primary ideology of our age. It hardly need be pointed out that the illusions scientism engenders are so pervasive and so insidious that it is practically impossible to get anyone who is subject to them to consider the possibility that they might be illusions.³

Modern science is an excellent thing: it has given us unprecedented understanding of the world and unprecedented ability to modify the world to satisfy our needs and desires. This does not mean that such non-scientific endeavors as art, literature, and philosophy have become less worthwhile, or that such 'softer' sciences as psychology and sociology are not important fields of knowledge. But the victims of scientism feel otherwise. Victims of scientism choose beliefs that express their attitude of exaggerated respect for natural science. Consequently, they prefer to believe that the hard sciences are the only important and genuine fields of knowledge, and that the things studied in the hard sciences are the only things that exist. As a rough analogy, compare the probable motivation for the medieval doctrine that all things depend upon God for their existence and would instantly pop out of existence were God to stop willing them to exist. Medieval philosophers said this, along with many other implausible things, for the purpose of further glorifying God and augmenting His importance in their philosophy. Similarly, victims of scientism, with few restrictions, adopt whatever philosophical beliefs they feel most glorify science.

For a victim of scientism, ethical intuitionism is obviously unacceptable, for two reasons. First, ethics is not part of hard science. Neither physics, nor chemistry, nor biology studies such things as 'rightness'. Neither the theory of the big bang, nor quantum mechanics, nor the theory of evolution can explain why murder is wrong. The most that science might do is to explain the causes of human moral attitudes. Therefore, surely, the attitudes are all that there is. If moral facts were to exist in addition, then there would be something not studied by scientists.

Second, intuition is, putatively, not part of the scientific method. I think this is actually quite false—I think intuition is essential to science⁴—but it is widely believed to be true. The victims of scientism believe that science is purely empirical knowledge. If there were such a thing as intuition, then some knowledge would be different from scientific knowledge; therefore, surely there is no such thing as intuition. The only form of moral realism that victims of scientism find worthy of consideration is ethical naturalism, and that is because the ethical naturalists try to assimilate moral knowledge to scientific knowledge. Only if it can be shown to be 'like science' can ethics be legitimate.

9.4.5 How intuitionism became 'implausible'

The strong, widespread opposition to ethical intuitionism, then, is the result of the confluence of at least three powerful and pervasive cultural trends. Most modern intellectuals have fallen prey to cynicism, political correctness, scientism, or some combination of these attitudes, and none of these attitudes fit well with intuitionism. My contention is that this led to intuitionism's fall from favor. But we must not understand this process in a simplistic way.

First, we should not think that those who rejected intuitionism generally did so by explicitly entertaining the reasoning I have described above; we should not think that the victims of scientism, for example, explicitly entertained the practical syllogism, 'I wish to believe only that which most glorifies science; ethical intuitionism fails to glorify science; therefore, I shall reject intuitionism'. The influence of such attitudes as scientism, cynicism, and political correctness is more subtle and insidious: these attitudes operate as biases, rather than explicit premises. They contaminate our judgments as to what seems 'plausible' on its face, which theories are most worth spending time investigating, which objections are 'important' and 'interesting', and so on. Thus, rather than reasoning from the premise 'Only that which glorifies science is true', victims of scientism are simply influenced to feel theories which amplify the importance of science to be 'more plausible' than those that do not. Victims of political correctness simply find theories which imply that some people are better than others 'implausible'. And so on. That is why many who hear about ethical intuitionism just consider it implausible on its face, for reasons they cannot articulate.

Of course, there could be other explanations: perhaps they find intuitionism implausible because intuitionism is, in fact, radically mistaken. But I have spent this book arguing that that is not so. Furthermore, if that were so, we would expect intuitionism to have also seemed implausible to people in many other cultures and at many different times. Instead, even anti-realists seem to admit that core tenets of intuitionism—particularly moral realism—have been assumed throughout most of the history of Western philosophy and are presupposed in ordinary moral discourse.[5] This suggests that anyone who considers moral realism counter-intuitive has anomalous intuitions that call for some special explanation. It seems more likely that the relatively recent shift in metaethical intuitions away from moral realism is due to the sort of peculiar cultural trends I have been discussing, than that the metaethical intuitions of almost all the rest of humanity throughout history have been severely skewed and that only now are we seeing things objectively.

Next, we should not suppose that the causes I have mentioned are the only ones responsible for the rejection of intuitionism, nor should we assume that the same causes have operated in all people who rejected it. It is quite possible that cynicism, political correctness, and scientism could ultimately explain the popularity of anti-realism, even if most anti-realists were not themselves victims of cynicism, political correctness, or scientism. To see why this is so, notice three points:

(a) That a minority may still constitute a plurality; thus, if 40 per cent of people hold theory $\$A\$$, this may be enough (provided more than two alternatives exist) for $\$A\$$ to be the most widely-held theory.

(b) That people's beliefs are strongly influenced by other people; there is a strong drive towards conformity. Odd as it may seem, it is probably true that most people in our society endorse anti-realism only because other people do. (Such people probably endorse anti-realism at a rather shallow level, and they may also hold attitudes incompatible with anti-realism.)

(c) That some people have a much greater intellectual influence than others—for instance, a professor, journalist, or artist probably influences others' philosophical beliefs more than an electrician would. Those who most influence others' philosophical ideas may be referred to as 'intellectuals'. Putting these three points together, we can see that, for moral anti-realism to have come to dominate our culture, it might have been sufficient that a sizeable minority of the intellectuals, who themselves are a small minority of society, should have succumbed to cynicism, political correctness, or scientism. The rest of society may have come to adopt anti-realism as a result of the influence of others.

I would not wish to be understood as claiming that reasons and evidence play no role in philosophical theorizing. But even if an individual accepts only those positions for which he can find plausible arguments, and accepts them on the basis of those arguments, non-rational biases may still play a decisive role in determining his belief system. To see why this is so, notice (a) that such biases may determine which positions one looks for arguments to support, (b) that there very often are plausible arguments for each of multiple competing theories, particularly in philosophy, and (c) that non-rational biases may affect how plausible one finds an argument. In view of points (b) and (c), a skilled philosopher who sets out looking for ways to defend a particular philosophical position will generally find some arguments that he will consider plausible (naturally, there are some limitations to this); thus, the decisive move is the one made right at the beginning, when one decides which theory to sympathetically investigate. And that move is typically more a result of bias than of arguments.

It goes without saying that, if I am right, anti-realist metaethical beliefs have generally been formed in an unreliable manner, through processes that are unlikely to lead to the truth. The fact that anti-realism enables one to express one's attitudes, feelings, or personality is no indication of its truth. The fact that moral realism causes some people to feel offended or hurts people's feelings constitutes no evidence against it. The fact that science is good and science does not study value is no evidence against the reality of value.

I do not expect my book to change all of this. Those who feel cynical, those who wish to glorify science, and those who feel offended by the idea of some cultures being more right than others will, for the most part, continue to reject moral realism. If they are philosophers, they will devise clever ways of trying to work around my arguments in this book. If they are not philosophers, they will ignore the arguments. Only a few will seriously consider changing their views. That, unfortunately, is the way of philosophy.

9.5 The importance of intuitionism

I would not have written this book if I did not think the truth of intuitionism mattered. It is important in two ways. First, it is theoretically important. Intuitionists posit a realm of facts—evaluative facts—different in kind from the facts recognized by all other views, and a way of knowing—intuition—different in kind from those recognized by all other views. The dispute between intuitionists and everyone else is thus a fundamental ontological and epistemological one. It is crucial to our general understanding of the world and our place in it.

Second, it is practically—morally—important. Anti-realist theories about value undermine our moral beliefs, our moral motivation, and even our sense of the meaning of life. They undermine our moral beliefs, because—as many anti-realists themselves admit—our ordinary, common sense moral beliefs are beliefs about a putative realm of objective value properties. When we say something is morally wrong, we do not merely mean that it goes against our preferences or customs, nor do we intend our remark to be heard as a mere expression of a non-cognitive emotional reaction. Most people will rightly take anti-realist arguments as implying that all we are entitled to say is something about our preferences or customs, or something expressing a non-cognitive attitude, which means that our moral beliefs are unjustified.

Anti-realist theories undermine our moral motivation, because they tell us that we have no good reasons for acting morally unless doing so will satisfy our desires. In truth, acting morally often is not, and does not appear to us to be, the best way to satisfy our desires. Most people who become convinced of the Humean account of reasons will thus draw the conclusion that they often have no good reason to be moral. (They will not instead assume that they have good reason to be moral and thence conclude that contrary to appearances, it must be that moral behavior really does satisfy their desires.) Furthermore, on the Humean theory of motivation, no person could possibly be motivated by anything other than desires; even if you were a moral realist and mistakenly thought that certain moral principles were objectively true and provided good reasons for action, the Humean would say, you still could not be motivated to act merely by those beliefs. I have argued that the Humean theory of motivation is false, and philosophers' endorsement of the theory cannot make it become true; however, telling people that they necessarily behave in a certain way has a tendency to make them behave more in that way than they otherwise would, provided they believe what you tell them. For instance, falsely telling people that everyone is completely selfish will tend to cause them—if they believe you—to start behaving more selfishly than they otherwise would. And falsely telling people that no one can be motivated by objective moral principles will tend to cause them—if they believe you—to try less hard to behave in accordance with objective moral principles. People have enough trouble with weakness of will and the temptations to rationalize selfish behavior, without philosophers telling them that disinterested moral concern is impossible and proclaiming all of morality a 'myth', as the title of one recent book has it.⁶

This last point assumes the truth of my account of moral motivation. If the Humean account of motivation is correct, then people already act solely in accordance with their desires; telling them the Humean theory cannot make them do so more. Indeed, none of what I have said in this section is evidence for intuitionism, nor is any of it my reason for endorsing intuitionism. It is only reason, given the truth of intuitionism, to think that truth is important.

Lastly, moral anti-realism undermines our sense of meaning in life, and this brings me to one of the reasons why I find anti-realism unbelievable. I think anti-realism really boils down to the view that nothing matters. Now, most anti-realists would deny this. They would proceed to devise interpretations of the sentence 'nothing matters' such that it means something that their theory is not committed to. They will say that 'nothing matters' expresses a non-cognitive emotional attitude that they do not in fact have; or that 'nothing matters' means that our society has no conventions for approving or disapproving of anything; or that it means that they themselves don't have any moral emotions; etc. All of this rings hollow to me. Despite what I know they would say, I think the anti-realist view is nevertheless that, in reality, nothing matters. Life has no

meaning, because 'meaning' is one of those 'spooky', non-natural properties that anti-realists do not believe in. The anti-realists would perhaps say that life may still be said to have meaning, because we can assign it some significance, simply by taking the appropriate non-cognitive attitude towards it. But this too rings hollow. One cannot honestly just 'assign' value to things while consciously regarding that assignment as merely arbitrary, and maintaining that from the objective standpoint, those things are without value. Moral values, like all beliefs, are jealous things: they contain an inherent claim to correctness.

If I believe that p , I am believing that p is true; I cannot consistently recognize the negation of p as an equally acceptable, or equally true, belief. Likewise, if I sincerely believe x is good, I regard my value judgment as correct; I cannot coherently recognize an equally (or more) correct perspective which assigns no value to x .

Admittedly, it is possible—as subjectivists and non-cognitivists have done—to devise interpretations of evaluative discourse such that one could deny objective value and yet still say things are 'really good' or 'really bad'. But as I have argued in previous chapters, these interpretations are simply false. When I say ' p is true', I do not merely mean 'I believe p '—and this, contra the truth-relativists, is something about which there is no serious question. Analogously, when I say ' x is good', I do not merely mean 'I value x ', or anything similar. In short, I think that among anti-realists, it is only the nihilists who are entirely forthright.

9.6 How I became a spooky, unscientific intuitionist

I have been a moral realist for as long as I can remember. I think the reason is roughly this: it seems to me that certain things, such as pain and suffering to take the clearest example, are bad. I don't think I'm just making that up, and I don't think that is just an arbitrary personal preference of mine. If I put my finger in a flame, I have a certain experience, and I can directly see something about it (about the experience) that is bad.⁷ Furthermore, if it is bad when I experience pain, it seems that it must also be bad when someone else experiences pain. Therefore, I should not inflict such pain on others, any more than they should inflict it on me.⁸ So there is at least one example of a rational moral principle.

But I was not always an *intuitionist*: when I first learned of the theory, in the form espoused by W. D. Ross, I thought that it rendered ethics unacceptably arbitrary. Ross had given a list of several different 'prima facie duties' that we have, such as the duty to keep promises, the duty to avoid causing harm, the duty to show gratitude for benefits given to us, and so on. Ross had no account of why these things were all duties, other than that it just seemed so to most people; nor had he any account of how to resolve conflicts between *prima facie* duties in particular cases, other than to just use one's best judgment.⁹ It seemed to me that this rendered most moral judgments doubly arbitrary: there was arbitrariness both in the general principles of duty themselves, and in their application to particular circumstances.

I am not sure, now, why I thought these things. If someone had asked me, 'Do you think that every belief requires an infinite series of arguments in order to be justified?' I would surely have said no. So what was 'arbitrary' about Ross' ethical views could not have been the mere fact that he advanced some claims without argument. I think I would have been satisfied, or at least less inclined to make the 'arbitrariness' objection, if Ross had stated a single ethical principle from which all other ethical principles could be logically derived—as, for example, the utilitarians do. No one makes the charge of arbitrariness against utilitarians. But this makes little sense—if a single foundational ethical principle may be non-arbitrary, why not two? Or six? Or a hundred?

At any rate, it was not the above considerations that brought me around to Ross' point of view. Instead, the turning point came when I noticed that there were many things I knew that I could never prove in any scientific, intersubjectively accessible way. And these were not some sort of mystical revelations, but perfectly mundane things that there was no serious doubt at all that I knew. A friend might call me on the phone and, after perhaps one second of speech, I would know who it was. She would not have to state her name or any other self-identifying information. If someone asked me how I knew who it was, I could say nothing more informative than, 'Well, it sounds like Sue'. Of course, there must be some combination of characteristics of the voice pattern that enable me to recognize it. Perhaps cognitive psychologists could figure it out. But I certainly couldn't tell you. Nevertheless, there is no serious doubt at all that I know Sue's voice.

Other examples of unprovable knowledge are easy to come by. Talking to a friend, I notice that he is upset about something; I couldn't tell you how I know. I couldn't give you a satisfactory definition of 'table', but I know that the object in front of me is one, and the object I'm drinking out of is not. Modern philosophers have tended to see science and mathematics as the paradigms of knowledge, and cases of unprovable knowledge as peripheral exceptions to the rule. But this, I realized, was severely skewed: unprovable knowledge is the norm. This is to say nothing against scientific or

mathematical knowledge, but they are the exceptions—an ordinary person may live an entire life and never do one mathematical proof or scientific experiment. But each of us constantly comes to know the sorts of things in my examples above.

So Ross' reliance on exercises of intellectual judgment in individual cases, in the absence of any identifiable algorithm, does not render his view of moral knowledge strange, in comparison with most human cognition. When we consider certain situations, such as the Trolley Car problem or the Organ Harvesting example,¹⁰ we find that we can judge certain actions to be right or wrong, even though we lack any systematic theory capable of computing the right answer in all cases. This does not render our judgments 'arbitrary', any more than my belief that I am talking to Sue on the telephone is arbitrary. It would take an absurdly skeptical disposition to declare that since I cannot specify a set of voice pattern properties by which one could identify Sue's voice, I don't know whom I am talking to.

A second important turning point occurred when I attended a lecture by Donald Davidson at Berkeley explaining his 'anomalous monism'.¹¹ Davidson's lecture concerned the relationship between mental states and brain states, but an analogous view might be taken of the relationship between moral properties and natural properties. It was Davidson's view that mental states supervene on brain states—it is impossible to have a change in one's mental state without some change in the brain—but that, nevertheless, it is not possible to pick out all the mental states of a given kind using only concepts from brain physiology. For instance, the mental state of believing that mosquitoes have small teeth might be capable of being realized by many different brain states, which might have nothing interesting in common when described solely in brain-physiology terms. Davidson explained at length that there was no conceptual difficulty in this. For me, what was important was that the obvious fact that moral properties depend on natural properties does not entail that one can identify some natural property, or even a finite disjunction of natural properties, that all morally right actions have in common. So there was nothing metaphysically absurd in Ross' picture of multiple duties that have no natural feature in common—that have nothing in common other than their being duties.

With that, my main source of resistance to intuitionism—the 'arbitrariness' objection—was defused, and I was free to accept that in the moral realm, things are, after all, essentially the way they appear. I have moral intuitions, just as nearly everyone else does. They seem to be cognitions of moral truths. It seems that such things as murder, torture, and theft are really wrong—and not just because I personally don't like them. I lay no claim to infallibility, either for myself or for the human community; it is logically possible that I and the rest of humanity are radically deceived (it is also 'possible' in the same sense that we are all brains in vats). But shouldn't we first see whether it can be maintained that everything is more or less the way it seems, before jumping to schizoid theories about radical delusions and errors? A plausible theory of morality cannot simply ignore our moral intuitions. Wouldn't it be simplest to say that the reason why we have the intuition that pain is bad is because pain is, in fact, bad, and our intuition is our awareness of that fact?

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